
Component 1: Language Variation

Overview

This component introduces students to the ways in which language varies, depending on the contexts of production and reception. Students will explore and critically evaluate how language choices can create personal identities. They will also explore and critically evaluate how language varies over time.

Learning outcomes

Students are required to appropriately and systematically:

- apply concepts relating to language variation to data drawn from written, spoken and multimodal discourse and from different time periods
- apply critical skills to description, analysis and evaluation of a range of data and discourses, including data from different time periods
- use and apply linguistic terminology accurately
- show their understanding of historical, geographical, social and individual varieties of English
- critically evaluate attitudes towards language and its users when discussing data, including texts from different time periods
- synthesise and reflect on language knowledge drawn from different areas of their studies of English language.

Content

Throughout this component, students will focus on how language varies, depending on:

- **mode:** the method of communication (spoken, written, multimodal)
- **field:** the subject matter
- **function:** the purpose
- **audience:** the relationship between writers/speakers and readers/listeners.

Students will study how the key language frameworks contribute to meaning in spoken and written English:

- **pragmatics:** variation in meaning, depending on context

In addition to the key language frameworks, the following language levels also contribute to meaning in spoken and written English:

- **graphology**: the writing system and the presentation of language
- **phonetics, phonology** and **prosody**: speech sounds, sound effects and intonation
- **morphology**: the structure of words
- **lexis**: the vocabulary of a language and **semantics**: its meanings
- **syntax**: the relationships between words in sentences.

Please ensure that students are familiar with the English phonemic reference sheet in *Appendix 5* and the transcription mark key in *Appendix 6*. The reference sheet and the mark key will be given to students in the examination.

Individual Variation

Students will explore how language choices reflect and construct the identity or identities of the user and vary depending on the contexts of production and reception.

Students will apply appropriate methods of language analysis to a range of written, spoken or multimodal data from 21st-century sources, using the key language frameworks and levels.

Students will demonstrate critical understanding of concepts and issues, exploring attitudes to language and using a descriptive approach to evaluate how an individual's language choices are affected by:

- the mode, field, function and audience
- geographical factors
- social factors, such as gender, age, ethnicity and other social identities.

Variation Over Time

Students will explore variation in the English language from c1550 (the beginnings of Early Modern English) to the present day.

Students will apply appropriate methods of language analysis and demonstrate critical understanding of concepts and issues when evaluating a range of data. Students will explore:

- the development of English as the national language
- the cultural, social, political and technological influences that have changed English over time.

Students will need to consider the effect of language variation over time across the language frameworks and levels, for example changes in:

- the writing and spelling system (**graphology and orthography**)
- pronunciation, evident in obsolete spelling and rhyme (**phonology**)

- sentence structures (**syntax**)
- vocabulary, evident in pronoun usage and the incorporation of words from other languages (**lexis**)
- meaning (**semantics**)
- the form (**style**) and structure of whole texts (**discourse**).